



ANDREW MEDICHINI Associated Press

A PAPAL TOUR OF AFRICA

Pope Leo XIV is cheered during his visit to a nursing home in Saurimo, Angola, on Monday. **WORLD, A2**

Mayor’s 2026-27 budget avoids layoffs

Bass spending plan holds the line. Rivals in primary demand more than ‘status quo.’

By DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass released a budget bombshell last year, stunning the city workforce by proposing widespread layoffs and other cuts in a bid to erase a \$1-billion spending gap.

On Monday, in the midst of a tough reelection fight, Bass unveiled a much rosier \$14.9-billion spending plan for 2026-27 that — thanks in part to increased tax revenues — avoids layoffs and keeps many city service levels unchanged.

With six weeks until the June 2 city primary election, Bass is seeking to hire 510 officers at the Los Angeles Police Department, enough to cover the retirements and resignations that are expected in that agency, according to her budget team.

The mayor is also planning to retain the same number of firefighters, holding off on any expansion of the Los Angeles Fire Department at least until November, after voters have determined the fate of a sales tax hike to pay for the department’s operations, her team said.

The budget, which must be approved by the City Council, also preserves the same level of services delivered by Inside Safe, the may-

[See Budget, A7]

Apple’s Tim Cook to step back. Next CEO named

Hardware chief John Ternus will succeed his mentor as the tech giant wrestles with AI.

By QUEENIE WONG

Apple, one of the world’s most valuable companies, is getting a new chief executive, marking a new chapter in the story of what has become arguably the most influential company in consumer technology.

The Cupertino, Calif., smartphone maker said Monday that John Ternus, senior vice president of hardware engineering, will become Apple’s chief executive on Sept. 1.

Tim Cook, who has served as chief executive for roughly 15 years, will become executive chairman of the company’s board of directors, the company said. He



EVAN AGOSTINI Invision/AP

TIM COOK has been CEO for about 15 years.

was long expected to step down soon.

Under Cook’s leadership, Apple’s market capitalization grew to \$4 trillion from about \$350 billion, according to the company. Its revenue ballooned from \$108 billion in fiscal year 2011 to more than \$416 billion in fiscal year 2025.

Apple also expanded its business under Cook’s tenure, including its presence in

entertainment with Apple TV and Apple Music. People also use other services such as Apple Pay and iCloud to store their photos, videos and other content.

The leadership transition marks a new era for Apple, which turned 50 years old in April. The company has revolutionized technology, selling popular consumer electronics including iPhones and smartwatches.

But the company has lagged behind as its rivals such as OpenAI, Google, Meta and more move quickly to dominate the artificial intelligence race. It has also had to grapple with tariffs and criticism for manufacturing its products in other countries, such as China and India, during President Trump’s second term.

“These will be big shoes to fill and the timing of Cook exiting stage left as CEO could make sense but also

[See Apple, A11]

COVID subvariant rising in state; seniors’ vaccine rates worrisome

By RONG-GONG LIN II

A highly mutated COVID-19 strain is circulating in California — raising concerns that disease activity could rise heading into the summer.

The emergence of the BA.3.2 strain, nicknamed “Cicada,” comes amid broader uneasiness about COVID vaccination rates among seniors — who are especially susceptible to the virus — and whether competency after back-to-back relatively quiet winters has

left the elderly vulnerable. The “Cicada” nickname refers to this subvariant’s apparent dormancy before it reemerged in 2025, akin to some periodically active insects of the same name.

The timing of the spread of the Cicada subvariant also underscores that COVID has lately morphed into more of a summer disease in California. In fact, the summer peaks of COVID in 2024 and 2025 were worse than their respective winter peaks, according to the California Department of Public Health — a stark departure

from the earlier years of the pandemic, when winter surges ripped through California with devastating regularity.

Instead it was the flu that was the dominant respiratory virus the last two winters, with this past season considered moderately severe.

“This Cicada variant may be increasing just in time for what for COVID is more of a summer hit,” said Dr. Neil Silverman, director of the Infections in Pregnancy Program at the David Geffen

[See COVID, A6]

Governor’s race becomes even more unpredictable

Two weeks before voters receive ballots, Becerra surges and Yee ends campaign.

By SEEMA MEHTA AND NICOLE NIXON

The most unpredictable California governor’s race in recent history took another set of dizzying turns on Monday, with former Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier Becerra surging after former Rep. Eric Swalwell dropped out in the face of sexual assault and misconduct allegations, and former state Controller Betty Yee ending her bid.

The race to replace termed-out Gov. Gavin Newsom is the first in a quarter of a century with no clear front-runner and a sprawling field of candidates who have been jockeying for the attention of Californians, who are just beginning to pay attention to the campaign two weeks before ballots arrive in their mailboxes.

“I certainly could not have imagined the twists and the disturbing turns that this race has taken,” Yee said as she announced she was dropping out. “But through it all, my values and my vision for California has never wavered.”

A poll released Monday by the state Democratic Party — its first since Swalwell (D-Dublin) dropped out — showed Becerra’s support jumped 9 points to 13%, placing him in a tie with Tom Steyer, the billionaire hedge fund founder turned environmental warrior. Former

Rep. Katie Porter of Orange County saw a slight bump to 10% from 7%, while the remaining Democrats in the contest were mired in the low single digits.

The party began the surveys out of concern that Democrats could be shut out of the governor’s race because of California’s unique primary system, where the top two vote-getters in the June 2 primary move on to the November general election regardless of political party.

“I continue to believe there are too many Democrats in the field,” California Democratic Party Chairman Rusty Hicks told reporters Monday. “My call for candidates to honestly assess the viability of their candidacy and campaigns still stands, especially if you are stalled in the single digits, seeing financial resources dry up and/or are failing to pick up additional support.”

Hicks and other party leaders and allies had unsuccessfully urged low-polling candidates to reconsider their candidacies before the filing deadline in an attempt to cull the field and avoid splintering the Democratic vote. Though most did not name candidates who they thought should think about their viability, Yee was widely believed to be among them.

Yee became emotional as she said on Monday that she decided to withdraw from the race because she wasn’t able to raise the resources necessary to compete in the state. She also said her message of competency and ex-

[See Race, A7]

Mixed messages from Trump as Iran tensions flare

Preparations for new talks proceed even as he says he’s ‘unlikely’ to renew ceasefire.

By AAMER MADHANI, MUNIR AHMED AND RUSS BYNUM

ISLAMABAD, Pakistan — President Trump offered mixed messages on Monday about the path ahead for the U.S. war against Iran, declaring that he was in no rush to end the conflict while also expressing confidence that further negotiations with Tehran will soon take place in Pakistan.

With the 14-day ceasefire to expire Wednesday, Trump whipsawed in telephone interviews and social media posts between measured optimism that a deal could soon be reached and warning that “lots of bombs” will “start going off” if there’s no agreement before the ceasefire deadline.

Trump indicated that he still expects to dispatch his negotiating team, led by Vice President JD Vance, to Pakistan’s capital of Islamabad for a second round of talks, even as Iran insisted it would not take part until Trump dialed back his demands.

Iran’s chief negotiator and parliament speaker, Mohammed Bagher Qalibaf, accused the United States of wanting Iran to surrender and added that on the contrary, Iran has been preparing “to reveal new cards on the battlefield.”

“We do not accept negotiations under the shadow of threats,” Qalibaf wrote in a post on X early Tuesday.

Trump insisted he feels no pressure to end the war until Iran agrees to his terms.

“I am under no pressure whatsoever,” Trump said on his Truth Social platform, “although, it will all happen, relatively quickly!”

Pakistani officials moved

[See Iran, A3]

In esports, this team is like the Dodgers

By SANDRA McDONALD

It might not be an Olympic sport, but an event in Santa Monica happening quietly for years would overflow SoFi Stadium.

A grassroots community event in the game “World of Warcraft,” the Race to World First is more of a marathon, sometimes lasting over a month.

Liquid Guild — led by Max “Maximum” Smith — is tasked to play through the most difficult group content in gaming, he said. They race with other groups to be the first in the world to complete it. On April 6, the L.A.-based team won the global compe-



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

TEAM LIQUID’S Josh Heiner, from left, Brandyn Hahn and Kevin Areal in the Race to World First.

tition in stunning fashion.

“It is the regular season, the Super Bowl and the playoffs all at one time,” Smith, 33, said.

Liquid is the Dodgers of “WoW” esports. The L.A.-based team has won the last three races in a row, and recently made this month’s competition their fourth. Winning requires not just the 20-man group playing the game — called a raid group — but dozens of analysts and support staff.

There’s no prize pool or gold medal to be won. In this race, a team of esports athletes stare forward at a screen instead of the starting line. Without each other,

[See Esports, A11]

Singer D4vd charged with murder

He abused Celeste Rivas Hernandez, 14, then killed, dismembered her, prosecutors say. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Amazon accused of price-fixing

Retailer pressured Levi Strauss, rivals to charge more, state Atty. Gen. Bonta says. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

A shower or two. L.A. Basin: 69/52. **B6**

Markets **A10**
Opinion Voices **A12**

The Raiders are on the clock

The Times’ Sam Farmer and other beat writers hold their annual NFL mock draft. **SPORTS, B10**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7 85944 00200 5